inferior agents against the wish of Mahomed Akbar Khan who on complaint gave redress as far as lay in his power'.[25] Lawrence went further, noting that 'Akbar gave up his palanquin to Ladies Sale and Macnaghten,' that he was 'invariably most courteous', especially to Lady Macnaghten, and that he assured the ladies 'that they were his "honoured guests, that they should want nothing he could supply them with, and that as soon as the roads were safe enough he would forward them to Jalalabad; in the meantime they could write freely to their friends"'. When Lawrence told Akbar that the prisoners needed a little money he was immediately offered a thousand rupees: 'on my giving him a receipt for it, he tore it up, saying such things were only required among traders, not between gentlemen'. Later, when Lawrence complained that he had been insulted by one of the servants, 'the Sirdar had the man soundly flogged, saying that "if that was not sufficient I might have his ears if I pleased"'.[26]

There was also surprisingly widespread recognition by the hostages of the more positive qualities of the Afghans. 'There is no doubt that Afghans and Europeans get on much better than Europeans and Hindustanis,' wrote Colin Mackenzie during his captivity. 'The Afghans are an extremely hardy, bold, independent race, very intelligent with a ready fund of conversation and pleasantry which renders them very agreeable companions . . . The Afghan gentlemen are extremely sensitive to courtesy, having excellent manners themselves.'[27] Vincent Eyre agreed: 'We found the Afghan gentry most agreeable travelling companions.' Lawrence found that on further acquaintance Sultan Jan, who had only a month earlier murdered his friend Captain Trevor, 'was naturally a fine-tempered man, and very fond of children'.[28jj]

The prisoners were considerably less positive about some of their own number. Lady Macnaghten, who had somehow managed to save her baggage, but refused to share any of her clothes, or her sherry, remained a figure disliked by all. The Anglo-Indian Mrs Wade was more unpopular still: soon after her arrival at Laghman, she divorced her English husband and eloped with one of her captors, converting to Islam, 'adopting the costume of the Mussalmans and professing to have changed her creed . . . She gave information of some plans laid by the men for their escape, which very nearly caused them all to have their throats cut . . . Having reported to her Afghan paramour the manner her husband had secreted some gold mohurs in his robes, he was of course plundered of them.'[29] Most hated of